

USDA ONBOARDING ACCELERATION

USDA | Office of the Chief Information Officer

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Summary:

To accelerate the hiring process in the USDA Office of the Chief Information Officer (OCIO), Wesley worked with an interdisciplinary team to design and develop an onboarding tracking tool. Utilizing **SQLModel**, **FastAPI**, and **React**, Wesley created a lightweight, legible, and reactive hire tracking tool that provides hiring managers in the OCIO with a centralized repository of information for recording dozens of hires at any given moment.

USDA ONBOARDING ACCELERATION

USDA Office of the Chief Information Officer

USDA-OCIO Special Unit

Fredy Diaz - Deputy Chief Data Officer

coding it forward >



WESLEY ALEJANDRO

The USDA needs to hire hundreds of people. **It takes 75 to 90 days for new hires to start working.** That time needs to be cut down.

BACKGROUND & CONTEXT

THE CURRENT SITUATION

The USDA Office of the Chief Information Officer (OCIO) is responsible for all things tech and data in the USDA. To accommodate expanding operations, the OCIO plans to hire hundreds of new employees in the coming months. Currently, the time-to-hire for a new employee ranges from **75 to 90 days**. Added up across dozens or even hundreds of new employees, this results in **thousands of hours lost** that could have been spent on service delivery.

The scope of this project focused on identifying areas within the onboarding process that can be expedited, and, if possible, to design and develop **lightweight, easy-to-learn software** to aid hiring managers in those areas.

RESEARCH & EXPLORATION

HIRING MANAGER WISHES

To find areas of improvement in the onboarding process, employees, contractors, and hiring staff in the OCIO were interviewed regarding their **pain points** in the hiring process.

Some common themes:

- Information is decentralized
- For some staff, **no software or tools** designed specifically for onboarding
- Communication latency
- New hires encounter fingerprinting obstacles

POTENTIAL SOLUTIONS

OUR TEAM'S RECOMMENDATIONS

Our team prepared several recommendations that, based on the evidence within the scope of this investigation, will contribute to the acceleration of the onboarding process. Presently, this presentation will focus on one of them: a proof of concept onboarding tracking tool for hiring managers.

WRANGLER

The **OCIO Onboarding Tracking Tool** (working name **Wrangler**) is a proof of concept web application intended to aid hiring managers in the onboarding process by providing a one-stop centralized hub for new employee information. It is **lightweight, easy-to-use**, and designed for future development in mind.

USER INTERFACE

 U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE

Hal Incandenza

Point of contact: contact@example.com

Milestones completed: 0/5

Fellowship: Coding it Forward

Email: test@example.com

☐
☐
☐
☐

Bob Ferguson

Point of contact: contact@example.com

Milestones completed: 0/5

Fellowship: Coding it Forward

Email: test@example.com

☐
☐
☐
☐

Front Page

Users can view new hire profiles.

USER INTERFACE

 U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE

Jonathan Harker

Fellowship: Coding it Forward

Email: test@example.com

Point of contact: contact@example.com

Onboarding Progress

☐ Document Package A

☐ Level 1 background check

☐ Equipment status

☐ LincPass

Mina Murray

Fellowship: Coding it Forward

Email: test@example.com

Point of contact: contact@example.com

Onboarding Progress

☐ Document Package A

☐ Level 1 background check

☐ Equipment status

☐ LincPass

Lucy Westenra

Fellowship: Future Leaders in Public Service

Email: test@example.com

Point of contact: contact@example.com

Onboarding Progress

☐ Document Package A

☐ Level 1 background check

☐ Equipment status

New Employee Profiles
Each new hire's information is displayed on their card.

USER INTERFACE

 U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE

Jonathan Harker Fellowship: Coding It Forward Email: test@example.com Point of contact: contact@example.com	Onboarding Progress ☒ Document Package A ☐ Level 1 background check ☒ Equipment status ☐ LincPass
Mina Murray Fellowship: Coding It Forward Email: test@example.com Point of contact: contact@example.com	Onboarding Progress ☐ Document Package A ☐ Level 1 background check ☐ Equipment status ☐ LincPass
Lucy Westenra Fellowship: Future Leaders in Public Service Email: test@example.com Point of contact: contact@example.com	Onboarding Progress ☐ Document Package A ☐ Level 1 background check ☐ Equipment status ☐ LincPass

Record task progress

Easily check off each hire's progress as the onboarding process goes on.

USER INTERFACE

The screenshot displays the USDA U.S. Department of Agriculture user interface. At the top, there is a header with the USDA logo and the text 'U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE'. Below the header, there are two buttons: 'Look up a hire' and 'Submit'. A modal form titled 'Create new hire profile' is open in the center. The modal contains three input fields: 'Name *', 'Email Address *', and 'Fellowship'. At the bottom of the modal are two buttons: 'Cancel' and 'Create profile'. The background shows a list of users with their details and onboarding progress.

Name	Fellowship	Onboarding Progress
Jonathan Harker	Coding It Forward	☐ Document Package A ☐ Level 1 background check
Mina Murray	Coding It Forward	☐ LINC Pass
Lucy Westenra	Future Leaders In Public Service	☐ Document Package A ☐ Level 1 background check ☐ Equipment status ☐ LINC Pass

Create new profile
Manually add a new hire profile.

USER INTERFACE

The screenshot shows a web interface for the U.S. Department of Agriculture. At the top left is the USDA logo. Below it, there is a search bar containing the text "Abraham van Helsing" and a "Submit" button. Below the search bar is a link that says "Create new hire profile". The main content area is divided into two columns. The left column is titled "Abraham van Helsing" and contains the following information: "Fellowship: Future Leaders in Public Service", "Email: test@example.com", and "Point of contact: contact@example.com". The right column is titled "Onboarding Progress" and contains a list of four items, each with an unchecked checkbox: "Document Package A", "Level 1 background check", "Equipment status", and "LincPass".

USDA U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE

Abraham van Helsing Submit

Create new hire profile

Abraham van Helsing

Fellowship: Future Leaders in Public Service

Email: test@example.com

Point of contact: contact@example.com

Onboarding Progress

- ☐ Document Package A
- ☐ Level 1 background check
- ☐ Equipment status
- ☐ LincPass

Search profile

Search for a hire profile by name.

USER INTERFACE

The screenshot displays the USDA U.S. Department of Agriculture user interface. At the top, there is a header with the USDA logo and the text "U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE". Below the header, there are three buttons: "Look up a hire", "Create new hire profile", and "Bulk profile creation". The "Bulk profile creation" button is highlighted with a red box. The main content area is divided into three sections, each representing a user profile: Jonathan Harker, Mina Murray, and Lucy Westenra. Each profile section includes fields for Fellowship, Email, and Point of contact, as well as an "Onboarding Progress" section with checkboxes for "Document Package A", "Level 1 background check", and "Equipment status". A modal dialog titled "Bulk profile creation" is open in the center of the screen, featuring a "Choose File" button, a "No file chosen" message, and "Cancel" and "Create profiles" buttons.

USDA U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE

Look up a hire Submit

Create new hire profile

Bulk profile creation

Jonathan Harker Onboarding Progress

Fellowship: Coding It Forward ☐ Document Package A

Email: test@example.com ☐ Level 1 background check

Point of contact: contact@example.com ☐ Equipment status

Bulk profile creation

Choose File No file chosen

Cancel Create profiles

Mina Murray Onboarding Progress

Fellowship: Coding It Forward ☐ Document Package A

Email: test@example.com ☐ Level 1 background check

Point of contact: contact@example.com ☐ Equipment status

☐ LincPass

Lucy Westenra Onboarding Progress

Fellowship: Future Leaders in Public Service ☐ Document Package A

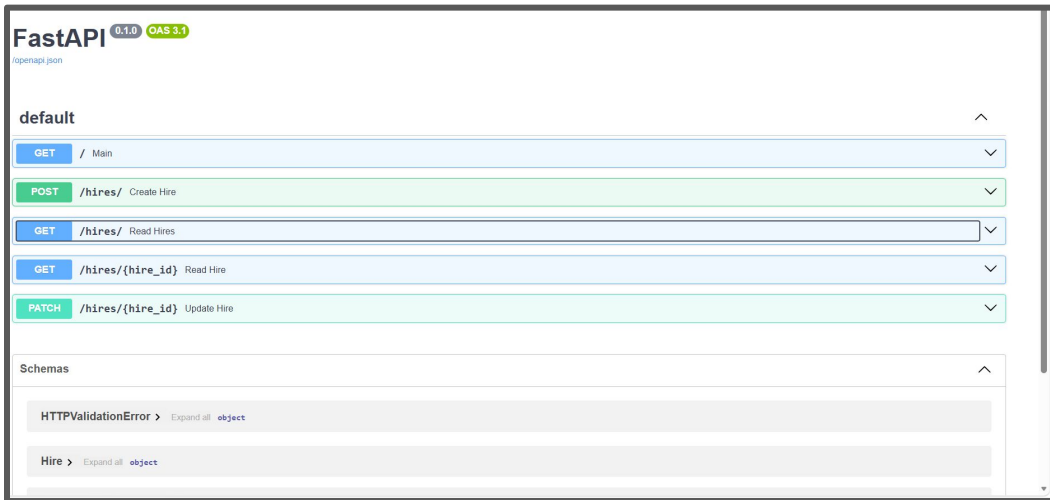
Email: test@example.com ☐ Level 1 background check

Point of contact: contact@example.com ☐ Equipment status

Bulk profile upload

Create multiple profiles at once from one JSON file.

BACKEND API



A **FastAPI** backend provides automatic documentation, ideal for future development.

Additionally, Wrangler uses **SQLModel** to generate a local, single-file database for testing and development.

REFLECTIONS

- There are steps within the OCIO onboarding process that present opportunities for expediting
- Some steps *should* take some time to be completed (like security checks)
- For other steps, tools like Wrangler can be used to cut down the time required

NEXT STEPS

There are several directions that Wrangler could take, including but not limited to:

- More robust search features, like filtering by employment type, fellowship, or task progress
- A transition to a larger database for enterprise deployment
- Authentication features to ensure only authorized USDA-OCIO staff may access the tool

CONCLUSION/CALL TO ACTION

Acknowledgments

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